

Accounts vary on location of 1877 battle of Yellow House Canyon

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EDITOR'S NOTE: *Caprock Chronicles* is written or edited by Paul Carlson, emeritus professor of history at Texas Tech University. Today's essay, by Austin Allison of Texas Tech's Southwest Collection, examines several first-hand accounts of the 1877 battle of Yellow

House Canyon, which may have occurred in present-day Mackenzie Park.

Precisely locating the 1877 battle of Yellow House Canyon remains a puzzle. It was a fight between bison-hide hunters and Comanches.

It traces its roots to a series of skirmishes on the Southern Plains between some angry Indian warriors and bison-hide hunters who in the early 1870s had been denuding the region of bison.

Herman Lehmann, a white captive turned Comanche, said the Indians were “desperate” and the “plains were being thoroughly combed by the buffalo hunters.” He also noted seeing many wagon loads of bison hides being hauled from the plains. When they left the reservation just after Christmas in 1876, the Comanches planned to hunt bison. They probably did.

But, they also raided several bison-hide hunter camps across the numerous tributaries of the Colorado, Brazos, and Red rivers. In early February 1877, the Comanches came upon Marshall Sewell’s camp at the headwaters of Deep Creek, a tributary of the Colorado River near modern day Fluvanna. They killed Sewell and sacked his camp. The event alarmed bison hunters and gave them a reason to retaliate.

From their dispersed camps bison hunters gathered at Rath City, a new trading post along the Double Mountain Fork of the Brazos River, and then headed west to find and punish the Comanches.

Divergent accounts describe the ensuing activities, but fighting occurred. John R. Cook, a Civil War veteran and author of *The Border and the Buffalo* (1907), insists that there were at least two skirmishes. He participated in the second one occurring on March 18th.

As to the March 18 fight, Cook, the most verbose participant, placed a Comanche camp at a location near Thompson's Canyon, an archaic name for the lower Blackwater Draw. He wrote that Comanches had selected a location in a "pocket-can(y)on just south of the mouth of Thompson's can(y)on." The fight probably took place there.

Frank Collinson, another witness, refutes Cook. "There never was a Thompson Canyon," he wrote in a 1937 letter. But, "Thompson's Canyon" is listed on several early maps of the South Plains, including one that Cook likely carried during his time hunting bison in the region.

Nonetheless, Collinson often ridiculed Cook's account of the skirmish, saying Cook embellished the affair to a greater extent than he (Collinson) remembered the engagement.

Collinson's letter noted that Indians "were camped on the hill right in the forks of the Yellow House draws" — meaning between Yellow House and Blackwater draws. A month later, he clarified by writing that the Comanche camp was "right in town [Lubbock]."

Cook never explicitly placed the Indian camp or the subsequent skirmish with as much specificity.

Historians of these events have often struggled with Cook's extensive, but often unspecific descriptions. Collinson, by contrast, wrote sparsely but with clear declaration placing the skirmish in Lubbock.

Willis Skelton Glenn, another Civil War veteran, around 1910 penned his recollection of the Yellow House fight. He offers information similar to Cook's account, but Glenn, like Cook, also lacks specificity in describing the location of the action.

Glenn uses the term "Yellow House Canyon" to denote the general area in which the skirmish occurred, but he does not elaborate other than providing vague geographic terms.

He also claims that the Comanche camp was located near a Mexican bison hunters' trail, one which crossed Lubbock County at the lower reaches of Yellow House Draw and Blackwater Draw. Collinson also refers to the trail in a 1938 letter.

The trail plays a role in describing the location of the fight. Both Glenn and Collinson claim that bison hunters used the trail upon their retreat from the field.

Although many trails crossed the Llano Estacado, one of the most prominent roads extended from the Pecos River near Fort Sumner, New Mexico, to a site referred to as “Punta del Agua,” the modern location of the Lubbock Lake Landmark.

Modern histories of the engagement point to the likelihood that it took place in or around Lubbock, but in recent years an alternate theory has emerged. It places the fight farther north along Blackwater Draw in Hale or Lamb County.

The theory involves a statement Cook made, saying that the Comanches retreated “toward the sand-hills four miles away.” However, there are no appreciable sandhills within even 15 miles of Lubbock.

It is such inconsistencies, small that some may be, that prevent scholars from pinpointing the exact location of where the conflict occurred.

Mackenzie Park, which lies at the mouth of Thompson’s Canyon, has been a popular meeting place for Lubbock and area residents for a

century. As a result, evidence related to the skirmishes from 1877 probably has been lost or removed.

Absent empirical evidence, such as bullets or cartridges, it remains difficult to establish an exact location for the March 18, 1877, battle of Yellow House Canyon.



